

VanGunst seemingly 'in the groove' in raising quality dairy breeding stock

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The lady's limpid eyes turned slowly to the side. The elegant head arched on the long neck. With the langorous elegance of the truly aristocratic, the lady shifted the mass of her ancient Holstein breeding and settled back into her stall with 89 of her milk-producing sisters at View Home Farms.

She is, after all, a full daughter of "Evolution," the highest-proven bull Select Sires of Plain City, Iowa, had graduated at the time he was added to their lineup in January 1982.

"There has been one bull do better since," Wendell VanGust said. "But at the time he graduated he was the highest rated bull they had ever had."

VanGunst wasn't really surprised that "Evolution" did well, because he knew the young bull's brothers and their performance. And he wasn't disappointed that "Evolution" — the progeny of his own farm — had been bested in competition. Better bulls mean better cows for milk producers, and that is what VanGunst likes to see, both in his own herd and for other producers.

He has promoted improved milk stock selection through artificial insemination about as long as he has been in the dairy business. He credits Clint Meadows of Michigan State University with promoting the interest and impetus that has led to an involved system of breeding selection and greatly improved milk production for Michigan herds in the last 30 years.

"The selection system takes only bulls from the top 2 percent," VanGunst explained. Selection criteria include milk production of female relatives, size of the animal, structure, legs, udder build ... qualities that would contribute to a strong, healthy, heavy producing milk cow.

"Of that top 2 percent, only one of a hundred actually passes into artificial insemination services," VanGunst said. The criteria are very strict.

"A very popular bull a few years ago passed on mulefoot, a condition where the cow's hoof is all one piece. He was taken out of service," he noted.

Cows are also selected by the United States Department of Agriculture, and two or three times a year lists are sent of the top 2 percent of cows. VanGunst had nine cows on the last list published. "Sometimes I don't have any," he added with a shrug.

His zeal for dairy farming and care in selective breeding have put his operation in the top 30 of dairy farms in Michigan. He averaged 21,148 pounds of milk per cow last year.

Wendell's grandfather, Andrew VanGunst, first bought the beautiful hilltop acreage where the city of blue silos now rises just north of M-20 off Oceana Drive.

"Grandpa was into potato farming," VanGunst recalled. "He really liked those potatoes. He did a lot of general farming, had some fruit and milked eight or 10 cows."

When the farm was sold to Wendell's father about 1975, the herd was expanded to 15 or 16 cows. Wendell said he always wanted to get into the dairy business, and when he bought out his father in 1968 he expanded the herd to 80 cows. He has added about 10 since then.

The VanGunsts breed their own dairy herd and sell breeding stock.

"We try to have a calf from every cow every year and hope that half are heifers," he said. Of the half of the calves that are bulls, half are sold and half are raised on the farm. Some of the Holsteins are bred naturally on the farm. The rest are bred selectively.

Although there are still some grade B dairy farms left in the state whose milk can be used only for pro-

cessed milk products, VanGunst is one of the majority of Grade A producers. Milk from View Home goes through the Michigan Milk Producers Assn. cooperative at Benton Harbor or Saginaw, and a portion of it is retailed under the McDonald's label.

"About 40 percent goes into fresh milk and some into butter and cheese. I'd like to see the restrictions on Grade A farms even stricter than they are now," he said.

Although dairy farming has always been a very expensive business, VanGunst says costs have skyrocketed in the past 10 years.

"Equipment is the biggest cost. A tractor that used to cost \$10,000 to \$15,000 sells now for \$46,000 to \$50,000. A silage chopper that cost \$5,000 10 years ago is \$20,000 today."

It wouldn't be impossible for a young farmer to start up in the dairy business today, depending on how badly he wanted to do it, VanGunst said. But it would be very difficult.

"I wouldn't have made it a lot of times if some of the banks around here hadn't taken an interest in the

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